

HATE IN TIMES OF PRAYER

India's religious festivals are enthusiastically celebrated at home and are world famous everywhere else. The crowds, the colour, the din, the passion. Not to mention the hatred, the obscenities, the bloodshed and broken bones. The bulldozers... Perhaps there was a time when it might have been considered a blessing that fasting days of the Navratras and Ramzan coincided as closely as they did this month. A conjunction that might cause observant Hindus and Muslims to reflect on their cultural affinities or even their common humanity.

This is not that time. This is not that country. Instead, we had a slow-motion pile-up of Hindu-Muslim clashes that snaked across our land in a sorry sequence that we may not have seen since the days of the Rath Yatra in 1990. Nothing about this is a coincidence, of course. Indeed, with so many decades of hindsight, it's hard to ignore the malice aforethought in this dismal itinerary: from a boycott of Muslim vendors in Karnataka, to the intimidation of butchers in the NCR, to the flag-waving motorcycle gangs displaying their machismo, to stones thrown and shots fired as they passed through the narrow lanes of a certain community. Yes, 'a certain community', 'narrow lanes,' 'mandir-masjid'—it doesn't take much to invoke the mise en scène of this miserably familiar narrative. We know riots don't just 'happen', that polarisation is political. Our eyes are trained to scan suspiciously past the headlines for the names that will betray the religious affiliation of the latest victim or perpetrator in the morning papers. And we have learnt to cluck to ourselves about the historic wounds to our wounded civilisation. The many invaders. Our divide-and-rulers.

The thing is, they don't rule us any longer, do they? Yet after over seven years of a muscular Hindutvist government in New Delhi, the enduring sense of grievance against Muslims remains fresh. For 'appeasment' politics, for Kashmiri separatism, for Islamic radicalism, for making a song and dance about hijabs. So why did the Ramnavami-Ramzan riots cause such consternation? Perhaps it was the 'weaponisation' of festivals (quite literally given the massed swords and firearms suddenly on display) or the eruption of an uninhibitedly extremist 'fringe' of sants and sadhvis, a self-appointed vanguard of militant majoritarianism. Do these phenomena signal an escalation of communal hostility, a deepening of the 'great divide'? Or are we witnessing just another episode, of our country's perversely punctuated equilibrium?

THE RAMNAVAMI-HANUMAN JAYANTI RIOTS HAVE BROUGHT INTO FOCUS THE 'WEAPONISATION' OF FESTIVALS

This week, we turned to a number of prominent, politically engaged voices to ask what auguries they see in the boiling communal cauldron. Their responses, which range from despair to muted warnings, are far from hopeful, but they do suggest that this festival of hate has given pause for thought at either end of the polarised political spectrum. As peace returns—to the growl of vengeful bulldozers, bans on religious processions, a strong-armed police presence on the streets and surveillance drones above, there is the disconcerting realisation that we are being taught to be grateful for order and authority. ■

THE HIJAB

The controversy around the hijab first erupted on January 1 at the Government PU College in Udupi, Karnataka, when six girl students claimed they were not allowed to enter classrooms wearing hijabs, a face covering. Their protest against the college authorities soon became a nationwide movement, with several states seeing similar protests. In a college in Karnataka's Mandya, when a Muslim girl was allegedly heckled by boys in saffron scarves chanting 'Jai Shri Ram', she shouted back, 'Allah hu Akbar'. The Karnataka government justified the ban on hijab in classrooms under its 1983 Education Act, under which, it said, it can issue directions to schools and colleges to ensure maintenance of public order. The matter reached the Karnataka High Court, which upheld the state government's order, saying the hijab was not essential to Islam. The matter is now pending with the Supreme Court.

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